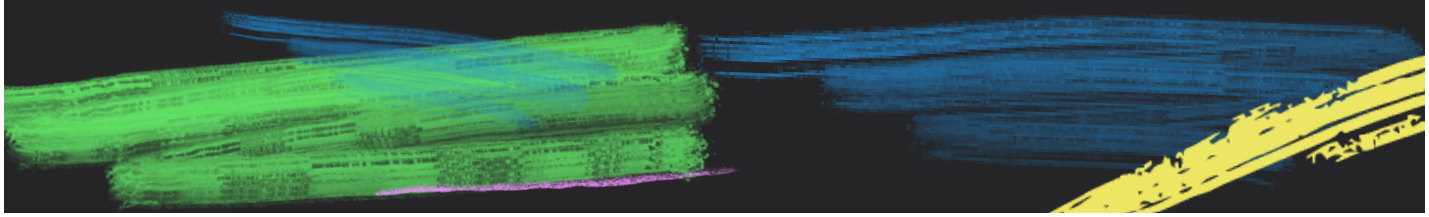
Refresh

REACH, A BRAND OF REFRESH · PUBLIC-SERVING DIVISION

# Know the Need

A summary for commercial customers and nonprofit agency recipients alike. How a needs assessment people answer for themselves, connected to resources and services, gives an employer or a nonprofit agency an immediate read on what its people need and where to invest.

Summary · about a 9-minute read



**What is in here.** One idea, followed from a person's first six minutes, to what an employer or a nonprofit agency learns about the people it serves, to how the work gets paid for on each side and what to call it. The last section holds every question and answer for the operations team. There is also a **PDF of this summary**.

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SECTION 1

## The insight

Every organization that serves people gets asked the same question. A nonprofit agency hears it from its board and its funders: what do the people we serve actually need? An employer hears it from its leaders every time it sets the total rewards budget: what does our workforce actually need? Today the honest answer is usually a guess, assembled months later from intake forms, program enrollments, benefits utilization reports, and whoever asked for help loudly enough to be noticed.

> **One sentence.** When a person answers sixteen plain questions about their own life, they see their next step in that moment, their employer or agency sees the need as it forms, and a resource or a case manager is in front of them before they leave.

That joins four things that have always been kept apart: finding out what someone needs, getting them what they need, knowing what a whole workforce or community needs, and deciding where the next dollar should go. On REACH they happen in one motion, for a commercial customer and a nonprofit agency recipient alike.

SECTION 2

## Community needs assessments exist. This is a different kind.

Assessing need is not new, on either side. Tax-exempt hospitals complete a Community Health Needs Assessment every three years, and Community Action agencies complete a community assessment on a similar cycle. Health systems use social-needs screeners such as PRAPARE and the CMS Accountable Health Communities screening tool. Human services agencies use self-sufficiency matrices, the best known being the Arizona Self-Sufficiency Matrix, and closed-loop referral platforms to send and track referrals. Employers run annual engagement surveys, read benefits utilization reports, and benchmark total rewards against other employers. Each is valuable, and each covers one part of the problem.

## Community needs assessments

**Describe a community**

Surveys, focus groups, and public data, published every few years. They guide strategy, but they cannot help the person who answered.

## Screeners

**Find a risk**

Usually a checklist that ends in a flag for staff. What happens next depends on who reads it, and when.

## Matrices

**Rate a household**

Usually scored by a case manager inside one program and reported upward. The person rarely sees the result.

## Referral platforms

**Send a referral**

Move a person between agencies, but only after someone else has decided what the need is.

## Engagement surveys

**Measure how work feels**

Ask about the job and the manager, once a year. They rarely ask about food, housing, or childcare at home, and they connect no one to help.

## Benefits reports and benchmarks

**Look back, or look sideways**

Show what a workforce used last year and what other employers offer, not what this workforce needs now.

### What makes this one of a kind

| | |
|---|---|
| **THE PERSON PLACES THEMSELVES** | Each of the sixteen areas asks one question with five answers in plain language, and the person picks the one that sounds like their life. Nobody scores them. Control over your own circumstances predicts how a life goes, so the assessment starts by handing that control back. |
| **THE ANSWER IS THE FIRST STEP OF THEIR JOURNEY** | Each answer sets the stage where the person's journey begins: Stabilize, Connect, Build Skills, or Maintain. Each stage already has three written steps with timeframes, and 720 written actions across the sixteen areas. The person leaves already on their way, with a first step and a date, not a flag in someone else's queue. |
| **ACCESS HAPPENS AT THE ANSWER** | The area chooses the kind of resource, and the answer chooses how urgent it is. REACH, or the organization itself, then surfaces the resources and programs that fit, near enough to reach. Where nothing fits yet, the organization finds the resource or budgets for it, so it can be made available. The assessment is not a report about need. It is the search. |
| **IT SHOWS WHERE TO INVEST** | Pooled by area and by tag, the same answers tell an employer or a nonprofit agency which benefits, resources, and programs to add, and for whom. A tag is a label on a person's account, such as where they came in, a site, or a program. |

**The claim we can defend.** Community needs assessments describe a community after the fact, screeners flag a person for someone else to act on, and engagement surveys and benchmarks tell an employer how work feels or what peers offer. We have not found another personalized needs assessment that gives a person access to resources and programs the moment they answer and, from the same answers, tells an employer or a nonprofit agency what to invest in next. If one exists, we want to learn from it.

SECTION 3

## How it works, end to end

From where the person sits, whether they are an employee, a participant, a community member, or a volunteer, they answered a few questions and left with help in hand. The machinery stays out of sight.

1

### A person answers

In their agency's app, or while getting started at work. Sixteen areas, one question each, about six minutes. Any question can be skipped.

2

### The answer sets the stage

Each area lands on Stabilize, Connect, Build Skills, or Maintain, with three steps and a first action with a date.

3

### REACH or the organization finds the resource

The commons surfaces what fits the area, the stage, and where the person lives. Where nothing fits yet, the organization finds or budgets for it.

4

### Or a case manager steps in

When the person asks for one, or the load is too heavy to carry alone, they connect with a local case management provider, or through the network with a Center of Excellence for that area.

5

### The account keeps the progress

Answers and steps live in the person's own portable account. Answering again later shows what moved, in their own words.

Three routes lead out of the same six minutes: a resource right away, a case manager, or both. The person's choice decides.

**A person is never a score.** There is no total. Sixteen areas are sixteen results, and a level describes a situation, never a person.

SECTION 4

## Part of onboarding, for both kinds of customer

The assessment belongs at the front door. When a commercial customer or a nonprofit agency joins, its people take it as part of getting started, and the organization gets its first clear read on the people it serves in weeks rather than years.

### Commercial customers

**Total rewards built on the workforce you have**

During onboarding, an employer learns what its workforce actually needs, from the physiological basics of food, housing, and a ride to work, up through mental health, family care, and connection. Work-life balance and overall wellbeing become visible instead of guessed at, so the total rewards budget goes to the benefits, perks, and supports this workforce will actually use.

### Nonprofit agency recipients

**Know participants, community members, and volunteers**

Nonprofit agencies and public-sector recipients of the REACH grant get the same read on the people they serve: participants, community members, volunteers, and their own staff. A community assessment done every few years gains a live companion, every person who answered already has a next step, and the grant pays for it on the agency's behalf.

The two customers buy for different reasons and learn the same thing. Employers that give hourly and gig workers access to supports they would not otherwise have are already one of REACH's commercial buyers, and the assessment shows them what to offer first. Nonprofit agencies already carry the mission, and the assessment shows them where their people are, so the next program, grant request, or partnership goes where it will land.

## In the rollout: the answers curate Phase 2

The rollout itself is the first use. As part of launch, an agency or an employer invites everyone who downloads the app to take the check-in. Phase 1 opens with the resources already on hand. The answers then curate Phase 2: which resources to invest in, which to find or budget for, and which people to guide toward what already exists.

1

**Launch**

Everyone who downloads the app is invited to take the check-in in their first week.

2

**Answer**

Each person gets a first step and the resources available today, right away.

3

**Read the pooled view**

After the first few weeks, the organization sees where the weight sits and where little is on offer.

4

**Curate Phase 2**

Invest in, find, or budget for what the answers call for, and guide people toward what already fits.

**The line neither one crosses.** Answers belong to the person. An employer or an agency's leadership sees pooled counts only, never a person and never a group small enough to point to one. Taking the assessment is voluntary. For employers, answers are never used for hiring, pay, promotion, or discipline, and because health and mental health questions asked on behalf of an employer carry disability, health privacy, and wellness program rules, counsel reviews any employer launch before it starts. The same protections hold when an agency looks at its own staff and volunteers.

SECTION 5

# What the organization sees

Once people are answering, the same answers, pooled, tell an employer or a nonprofit agency something it has never had in real time: what the people it serves need, area by area, this month.

| Where the weight sits | Where the commons is thin | What moved |
|---|---|---|
| How many people are at Stabilize in Housing, or at Connect in Transportation, and whether that number is growing. Sixteen distributions, not one index. | The areas where people land at Stabilize and little is nearby to offer. That tells the organization what to find or budget for, partners what to add, and funders what to fund. | Whether people who started at Stabilize reached Connect, by area and over time. This is the evidence funders, boards, and leadership increasingly ask for. |

### For a commercial customer: 1,200 employees

An employer with 1,200 employees onboards. In Nutrition, 600 of them, half the workforce, land at a stable level: they and their families have enough food, using their own income. Only five answer that they or their family often went without meals.

**What that changes.** The obvious move would be bulletin boards about SNAP and case manager training on food assistance, and it would speak to almost no one. For this workforce the useful investment is eating well on a budget: recipes, healthy eating challenges, and help planning a food budget. The money that would have gone to a food assistance campaign can go to the area where the weight actually sits.

The five are not forgotten. Each one was linked to food help, and offered a case manager, privately, the moment they answered. The employer's view shows them as "fewer than 10," because a number that small could point to a person.

### For a nonprofit agency recipient: 900 participants and volunteers

A nonprofit agency onboards its participants, community members, and volunteers, about 900 people in all. In Transportation, 360 of them land at Stabilize or Connect: no reliable transportation, or transport they can't count on. In Housing, most land at a stable level.

**What that changes.** The agency had planned its next grant request around a housing workshop. The answers point to rides instead: help with car repairs, transit passes, and volunteer drivers for work and appointments. The budget, the next grant application, and the volunteer recruitment all go where the weight actually sits.

**Know the Need, as a nonprofit agency would see it.** The nonprofit agency example above, drawn out: sixteen distributions, not one score. Each row counts only the people who answered that question, so the percentages are of that row's own answers.

| AREA | ANSWERED | OPTED OUT | 1 · STABILIZE | 2 · CONNECT | 3 · BUILD SKILLS | 4 · MAINTAIN | 5 · THRIVING |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mental Health | 612 | 288 | 67 11% | 134 22% | 214 35% | 147 24% | 50 8% |
| Transportation | 900 | — | 150 17% | 210 23% | 264 29% | 198 22% | 78 9% |
| Workforce Development | 900 | — | 126 14% | 234 26% | 270 30% | 198 22% | 72 8% |
| Communication | 900 | — | 54 6% | 126 14% | 288 32% | 306 34% | 126 14% |
| Education Stability | 900 | — | 63 7% | 153 17% | 306 34% | 279 31% | 99 11% |
| Environmental Health | 900 | — | 36 4% | 108 12% | 270 30% | 333 37% | 153 17% |
| Family Care | 900 | — | 27 3% | 90 10% | 243 27% | 369 41% | 171 19% |
| Financial Stability | 846 | 54 | 135 16% | 245 29% | 270 32% | 153 18% | 43 5% |
| Health Behavior Promotion | 900 | — | 54 6% | 144 16% | 297 33% | 288 32% | 117 13% |
| Health Care Access & Quality | 873 | 27 | 61 7% | 148 17% | 279 32% | 270 31% | 115 13% |
| Housing | 900 | — | 45 5% | 126 14% | 234 26% | 351 39% | 144 16% |
| Nutrition | 900 | — | 72 8% | 162 18% | 288 32% | 270 30% | 108 12% |
| Feeling Safe | 671 | 229 | *fewer than 10* | 61 9% | 191 28% | 268 40% | 143 21% |
| Social Connection | 900 | — | 45 5% | 135 15% | 288 32% | 306 34% | 126 14% |
| Legal & Civic Stability | 695 | 205 | 41 6% | 88 13% | 156 22% | 297 43% | 113 16% |
| Essential Goods | 882 | 18 | 36 4% | 117 13% | 252 29% | 315 36% | 162 18% |

Darker means further from stable, so the eye lands where the weight sits. The level number is always beside the colour, never colour alone. **Answered** counts only the people who agreed to share; **Opted out** is everyone who skipped that question, and the two always sum to 900. Any group smaller than ten reads *fewer than 10*, because a number that small could point to a person. No total, no ranking, and no level shown as who someone is. The numbers are illustrative.

In both cases the lesson is the same, and it is the case for sixteen distributions instead of one wellbeing score. A single index would have averaged the few people in hardship into the many who are steady, and hidden both. *The numbers in both examples are illustrative.*

**What exists today.** The individual experience is written: the questions, the answers, the stages, and the steps. The pooled view is a design, not a finished product. It must show pooled counts only and never an individual, it must hide any group too small to keep people anonymous, and it must count only people who agreed to share. The account belongs to the person, and that does not change when their answers help a workforce or a community see itself.

SECTION 6

# How it pays for itself

The assessment does not add a new cost for either customer. It points money that already exists at the right person sooner. Employers already budget for benefits and wellbeing. Private, public, and restricted funding already pays nonprofit agencies for outreach, screening, and enrollment. This puts that spending where the need is.

THE COMMERCIAL CUSTOMER GAINS

### Total rewards spent where they land

- Benefits, perks, and supports matched to what its workforce actually needs
- Less spent on programs few employees use, more on the ones they will
- Onboarding and platform fees are its investment in that view

THE NONPROFIT AGENCY RECIPIENT GAINS

### Funded work, found sooner

- The REACH grant, or the agency's own restricted funding, pays for the resource toolkit as procured technology
- People who need what the agency is already funded to deliver find it sooner, and enroll when they are eligible
- Outcome evidence that helps it renew and expand what it wins

THE CASE MANAGEMENT PROVIDER INVESTS

### Curated marketing

- Shown to the people whose answers match what it does, by area, stage, and place
- Funds curated marketing, not a fee per referral
- Uses the resource toolkit with the people it serves

REFRESH EARNS

### Marketing and tools, not referrals

- Onboarding and platform fees from commercial customers
- Curated technology services paid through the REACH grant for nonprofit agency recipients
- Curated marketing funded by case management providers

How curated marketing is priced is still open. **Decentralized Mission Services** sets out how agencies, funders, and people themselves pay for the services on the network.

**The boundary that keeps this clean.** Refresh facilitates and equips. It does not employ the case managers, does not set eligibility, and does not take a cut that varies with whether someone enrolls in a public benefit. Refresh is paid to market a case management provider to the people it can help, never for a referral. An answer on the assessment is never billable in itself, and counsel reviews how curated marketing is priced before any provider of a publicly reimbursed service takes part.

And the revenue follows the people. Organizations that hold a large, active, well-served population earn from it. The assessment is how that population learns what it needs, and a reason to keep coming back.

SECTION 7

## What we will not do

### Screen without a way to respond

Asking someone about food and then showing an empty list is extraction, not help. Launch where there is something to offer, and use the pooled view to find or budget for the rest.

### Treat an answer as an emergency

A hard answer describes a situation, not an emergency. Emergencies come from what a person tells someone, and each organization's own crisis policy decides who responds.

### Score, rank, or label people

No total, no ranking of people, and no level shown as who someone is. People know when they are being judged.

### Show an employer one person's answers

Employers see pooled counts only, and nothing an employee answers is ever used in a decision about their job.

### Sell referrals

Providers fund curated marketing. No one pays for a person.

### Claim outcomes we have not measured

There is no outcome data yet. What we have is a design traceable to Marmot, Mullainathan and Shafir, Hicks, Desmond, and Schwartz, and to teams who have practiced this for a century.

SECTION 8

## What to call it

Two things need names: what a person takes, and what an organization sees. Neither carries the REACH name. REACH is the grant program that pays for this on behalf of others, so the names belong to Refresh and to the person's own journey, and they have to work for an employee and a participant alike.

## The family name

**Refresh Personal Journeys** is the working name for the whole experience: the questions, the stage each answer sets, and the steps that follow. It names what the person gets, a journey that is their own, rather than something done to them.

## What a person takes

"Assessment" is accurate, but it reads like a test someone can fail. Each option below keeps the Personal Journeys name and changes that one word.

| First choice, not decided | Alternative | Plain |
|---|---|---|
| **Personal Journeys Check-In**<br>Warm, plain, and repeatable: you check in again later and see what moved. Works inside a nonprofit agency's own app ("Goodwill Marion Check-In, powered by Refresh") and at work without needing an explanation. | **Personal Journeys Starting Point**<br>Says exactly what the first answer is: the first step of the journey. Reads less naturally the second and third time someone answers. | **Personal Journeys Assessment**<br>What funders, procurement teams, benefits buyers, and RFPs already search for. Best kept for proposals and contracts rather than the screen a person sees. |

Other words that work in place of "assessment" are **Journey Map**, which fits the journey idea, **Self-Check**, and **Profile**. Words to avoid are **screening**, which sounds like an eligibility test, **evaluation**, which sounds like judgment, and **snapshot**, because the point is a path forward, not a picture of what is wrong.

## What an organization sees

**Know the Need** is the working name for the pooled view that an employer or a nonprofit agency sees. It is short, and it says what the view is for.

**On "culture management."** It fits the commercial side, where the buyer is HR and total rewards. It does not fit a person at a food pantry, who is not managing a culture. One answer is a single instrument with two labels: the Personal Journeys Check-In for people, and a culture and wellbeing view for employers. None of these names has had a trademark search.

SECTION 9

# Decisions this needs

| | |
|---|---|
| **THE POOLED VIEW** | What employers and agencies see, which tags they can filter by, the smallest group ever shown, how consent is asked, and who can see what. This needs a privacy review before any customer sees pooled answers. |
| **EMPLOYER LAUNCH** | Counsel's review of health and mental health questions offered through an employer, how voluntary participation is kept voluntary, and the smallest group an employer can see. |
| **THE GRANT** | Which curated services the REACH grant covers for nonprofit agency recipients, and how that differs from what a commercial customer pays at onboarding. |
| **WHO GETS A CASE MANAGER** | The rule that offers one, set against real case manager capacity in each market. The person's own choice always decides. |
| **THE MODEL** | How curated marketing is priced for case management providers, and counsel's review of it for providers of publicly reimbursed services. |
| **ALL SIXTEEN, OR A SHORT FIRST PASS** | Scarcity argues against asking sixteen questions of someone in crisis. The alternative is a short first pass, with more depth only where it is needed. |
| **THE NAME** | Which option in Section 8 people and customers see, followed by a trademark search. |

SECTION 10

# For the operations team: the questions and answers

Everything needed to set up the check-in is in this section. Ask the questions in this order. Answers always appear from A to E, and a person sees letters only, never a level name.

**Read or show this first.** These answers help us connect you with resources that meet what you need right now. This is about your situation, not about you. There are no right or wrong answers, and nothing here is a score. There are 16 short questions about different parts of life. For each one, pick the answer that sounds most like your life right now. If a question doesn't fit you, or you'd rather not answer, skip it. Your answers help us find where to start, and you decide what to work on first.

## The sixteen questions

In the app the areas sit in five groups: Food & Essentials, Home, Health & Care, Work & Learning, and Money & Legal. Feeling Safe has its own pathway rather than a tile in a group.

### 1 · Mental Health

**How are you feeling most days?**

- **A** I feel really bad or overwhelmed and don't know how to handle it.
- **B** I feel stressed or worried a lot, and it makes daily life hard.
- **C** I'm doing okay, but I need support or tools to stay steady.
- **D** I feel mostly good and have healthy habits that help me stay that way.
- **E** I feel strong, calm, and do things regularly to take care of my mental health.

### 2 · Transportation

**How would you best describe your current transportation situation?**

- **A** I have no access to reliable transportation.
- **B** I depend on others or on transport I can't count on.
- **C** I can usually get around, but cost or reliability is a problem.
- **D** I have consistent, affordable transportation through my own means.
- **E** I can get where I need to go, reliably and affordably, without help.

### 3 · Workforce Development

**How would you best describe your current employment situation?**

- **A** I am unemployed and not engaged in any job-related activities.
- **B** I work part-time or temporary jobs without benefits.
- **C** I work full-time, but my pay alone doesn't cover my basic needs.
- **D** I work full-time with pay and benefits that cover my needs.
- **E** I have a stable career with opportunities for advancement and financial security.

### 4 · Communication

**Do you have a working phone and internet, and can you understand the information you get?**

- **A** I don't have a working phone or internet.
- **B** I have some access via phone or internet, but devices, internet, or language get in the way.
- **C** I manage, but I need help with technology or understanding information.
- **D** I communicate well and have the tools I need most of the time.
- **E** I have everything I need to stay connected and informed.

## 5 · Education Stability

**Are you or your family able to meet your school or learning needs, if you have any?**

- **A** I or my family cannot meet important school or learning needs, even with help.
- **B** I or my family often miss school, fall behind, or cannot meet learning needs because of problems we face.
- **C** I or my family are meeting learning needs, but we need regular help from others.
- **D** I or my family are meeting our school or learning needs without regular help.
- **E** I or my family have met our current learning needs and have the tools and support to reach new learning goals if we choose.

## 6 · Environmental Health

**Which statement best describes the health and safety of where you live?**

- **A** I do not have a safe place to live, or where I live has serious health or safety problems.
- **B** Where I live has health or safety problems that are not being fixed.
- **C** Where I live has some health or safety problems, but I am getting help to fix them.
- **D** Where I live is safe and healthy, with no known problems that need to be fixed.
- **E** Where I live is safe and healthy, and steps are taken to prevent future problems.

## 7 · Family Care

**How well are you able to care for the people who depend on you?**

- **A** I cannot meet the basic needs of people who depend on me, and they may be unsafe.
- **B** I have trouble meeting some basic needs of people who depend on me, and they sometimes go without care.
- **C** I'm doing okay but still need help staying organized or supporting others.
- **D** I meet my family's needs well and have good routines at home.
- **E** My family or household feels strong, supported, and connected.

## 8 · Financial Stability

**Which statement best describes how you manage your money and pay your bills?**

- **A** I do not have enough money to pay for basic needs like food, housing, or utilities.
- **B** I can pay for some basic needs, but I often fall behind on bills.
- **C** I can meet my basic needs, but I have little or no savings.
- **D** I pay my bills on time and have some savings.
- **E** I pay my bills on time, have money saved for emergencies, and am saving for future goals.

## 9 · Health Behavior Promotion

**In the past 30 days, how well have you been able to care for your health through eating, sleeping, being active, and other daily habits?**

- **A** I'm finding it hard to eat, sleep, or stay well daily, and most days are a struggle.
- **B** I want to take better care of myself, but it's hard to stick with.
- **C** I have some healthy habits, but I have trouble keeping them up most days.
- **D** I follow habits that help my health most days, with or without help from others.
- **E** I follow habits that help my health most days and take steps to prevent future health problems.

## 10 · Health Care Access & Quality

**In the past 12 months, how well have you been able to get the health care you or your family needed?**

- **A** I or my family could not get needed care, and our health or safety was at serious risk.
- **B** I or my family missed or delayed needed care because of cost, transportation, or other problems.
- **C** I or my family received some needed care, but we still have trouble getting all the care we need.
- **D** I get regular care, follow medical advice, and keep up with appointments.
- **E** I manage my own care and know how to use the health system.

## 11 · Housing

**How would you best describe your current housing situation today?**

- **A** I do not have a steady place to live and am staying in a shelter, outside, or somewhere temporary.
- **B** I have a place to stay, but I may have to leave soon or do not know how long I can stay.
- **C** I have a place to live, but I need help to keep it or find housing that meets my needs.
- **D** I have a steady place to live that meets my needs, and I am not at risk of losing it.
- **E** I own my home or am building savings or other assets to help keep my housing stable for the future.

## 12 · Nutrition

**In the past 3 months, how well have you been able to get enough food for yourself and your family?**

- **A** I or my family often went without meals because we did not have enough food.
- **B** I or my family don't always have enough food, even with help.
- **C** I or my family have enough food, using my income along with SNAP or other help.
- **D** I or my family have enough food, using my own income.
- **E** I or my family can buy the food I need and may have excess to share.

### 13 · Feeling Safe

**In the past 30 days, have you or your family faced threats, violence, or unsafe situations at home or in places you spend time?**

- **A** I or my family are in danger because of violence, threats, or other unsafe situations.
- **B** I or my family have faced threats or unsafe situations that have not been fixed.
- **C** I or my family have safety concerns, but steps are being taken to keep us safe.
- **D** I or my family have not faced threats or unsafe situations, and we have no known safety concerns.
- **E** I or my family have no known safety concerns, and we know where to get and share help if a safety problem happens.

### 14 · Social Connection

**In the past 30 days, how connected have you been to people you can talk to or count on for help?**

- **A** I have no one I can talk to or count on when I need help.
- **B** I have limited contact with other people and no close social relationships.
- **C** I have some social connections, but I want more chances to spend time with others.
- **D** I have regular contact with people I enjoy spending time with or talking to.
- **E** I have people I can count on, stay in touch with them, and also support others when I can.

### 15 · Legal & Civic Stability

**How would you best describe any legal issues or missing documents that affect your daily life (such as ID, court matters, fines, a record, or child support)?**

- **A** I have a legal problem right now (like a court date, eviction case, or no ID at all) and no one helping me with it.
- **B** I have legal issues or missing documents that keep me from getting work, housing, a driver's license, or benefits.
- **C** I am working on my legal issues or documents with help from a lawyer, case manager, or program.
- **D** I have the documents I need, and no legal problems are keeping me from meeting my needs.
- **E** I have the documents I need, no legal problems that limit my life, and a plan to keep my important records up to date.

### 16 · Essential Goods

**Can you get the everyday items you and your family need — clothing, shoes, hygiene products, bedding, household basics?**

- **A** I am missing basic items needed for my health or safety, such as warm clothing, shoes, or hygiene products.
- **B** I have items needed for my health and safety, but I am missing things needed for daily life, such as kitchen supplies, cleaning products, or basic furniture.
- **C** I have the everyday items my household needs, but I do not have a reliable way to replace them when they wear out or break.
- **D** I can buy all household items we need and am able to donate to help others as needed.
- **E** I can buy what we need, plan ahead for bigger purchases, and am able to donate to help others.

Every question also offers **Skip this question**. A skip is recorded as skipped, never as A.

## Staff key

| | |
|---|---|
| **A** | Level 1 · Crisis: immediate action needed. The journey starts at Stabilize. |
| **B** | Level 2 · Vulnerable: a major barrier to work, learning, or stability. The journey starts at Connect. |
| **C** | Level 3 · Dependent: managing with support, still needs help to progress. The journey starts at Build Skills. |
| **D** | Level 4 · Independent: stable in this area. The journey starts at Maintain. |
| **E** | Level 5 · Thriving: a strong foundation, exceeding expectations. The journey starts at Maintain. |
| **SKIPPED** | Not scored, and never treated as A. |

**Before launch.** Show the help numbers, 911, 988, and 211, to everyone at the end, whatever they answered, and confirm them against the organization's own crisis policy. Whoever answers A on Mental Health sees 988 before any plan. Ask the Feeling Safe question in private, give it a quick exit, keep no history of it on the device, and never write its details into a shared record. No single answer triggers an emergency alert on its own; emergencies come from what a person says.